

Session 17: Possible Solutions

Key Takeaways

- Interpretations of this passage could be categorized by whether it is dealing with head coverings or hairstyles and by whether it is teaching a hierarchy or not.
- Most scholars agree that 1 Corinthians 11:6 is a *reductio ad absurdum* argument.

Interpreting 1 Corinthians 11:2-16

A good place to start with interpreting a difficult passage is to simply map the possible solutions to the problems that are currently offered by scholars. This material won't go through each point in detail, but all the different positions can be found summarized in *Women and Worship at Corinth* (Peppiatt, 2015).

"[T]his passage is probably the most complex, controversial, and opaque of any text of comparable length in the New Testament. A survey of the history of interpretation reveals how many different exegetical options there are for a myriad of questions and should inspire a fair measure of tentativeness on the part of the interpreter."

Blomberg, Craig (1994). [*1 Corinthians: NIV Application Commentary*](#). Zondervan. 214.

"Along with these larger contextual questions, this passage is full of notorious exegetical difficulties, including (1) the 'logic' of the argument as a whole, which in turn is related to (2) our uncertainty about the meaning of some absolutely crucial terms and (3) our uncertainty about prevailing customs, both in the culture(s) in general and in the church(es) in particular (including the whole complex question of early Christian worship). Thus the two crucial contextual questions, what was going on and why, are especially difficult to reconstruct."

Fee, Gordon D. (1991). [*The First Epistle to the Corinthians*](#). Eerdmans. 492.

Readings of 1 Corinthians 11:2-16 could be categorized in four ways.

1. Head coverings/hierarchical
2. Head coverings/non-hierarchical
3. Hairstyle/hierarchical
4. Hairstyle/non-hierarchical

Points of Contention

1. Head coverings or hairstyles?
2. One narrative/theology or two?

3. A unified narrative/theology or a tensive narrative/theology?
4. Creation or culture?
5. *Kephale* as ruler or source?
6. Authority as imposed upon or conferred upon women?
7. Does this apply to all men and all women or only to married men and married women?

Four Main Interpretive Strategies

1. A subordinationist reading: Paul is a subordinationist in relation to men and women and believes that women need a sign of authorization on their heads to pray and prophesy in public.
2. A tensive reading: Paul believes in some kind of subordination of women to men and also in their equality as reflected in the two sections of 1 Corinthians 11:2-10 and 1 Corinthians 11:11-16.
3. A rhetorical reading: Paul is engaging with the Corinthian men who are putting women in head coverings on the basis of a misunderstanding over headship, and Paul is rebuking them.
4. A cultural reading: Paul believes that women and men should dress or arrange their hair in certain ways to protect one another from shame in the prevailing culture.

A fifth option is to admit we don't understand the passage and to leave it as obscure, but evangelicals generally do not relate to Scripture in this way.

Reflection Question

Do your best to summarize Lucy's reading/interpretation of 1 Corinthians 11:2-16.